

Tao Xu, M.Sc.

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Rerum cognoscere causas, a motivated individual graduating with the highest distinction from NUFE and a merit from the University of Edinburgh, preparing my doctoral application in the political economy of development to study the micro-foundations of industrial policy and political settlements from an ideological change perspective. Proficient in NVivo, Stata, ArcMap and open to both qualitative & quantitative methodologies, with extensive industrial and academic experience gained from Mazars, Deloitte, Duke Kunshan, NUFE, NJU, UoEdin, SUFE, and Fudan. Committed to continuous personal development, and seeking more professional challenges in international organisations and research universities to apply my knowledge and a transferable skill set.

SKILLS & RESEARCH INTERESTS

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|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------|--|
| ▪ Political Settlements Framework | ▪ Critical Political Economy of Urban | ▪ Techno-nationalism and Innovation |
| ▪ Political Economy of Industrial | & International Development | ▪ Clientelist Rent-Seeking in Urban |
| Policy and Development | ▪ Micro-foundations of Industrial | Industrialisation & Structural Change |
| ▪ Industrial Policy & Governance | Policy and Political Settlements | ▪ Transport Infrastructure in Industrial |
| ▪ Institutions and Development | ▪ Institutional & Ideological Change | Policy and Structural Transformation |

QUALIFICATIONS & AWARDS

M.Sc. Development Studies (International Development, Merit) - The University of Edinburgh, Nov 2024

Dissertation Topic: The Road Not Taken? Industrial Policy and Political Settlements in China and Indonesia 1990–2022

Supervisor: Hazel Gray, Ph.D., Senior Lecturer in African Studies & International Development

Key Modules: Anthropology of International Development; Politics and Theories of International Development; Research Design & Practice; Resource Politics and Development; Interpreting Development Institutions & Practices; Governance, Development and Poverty in Africa; Key Skills in Development Practice

B.Sc. Economics (Commercial Economics, 1st: 91.29) - Nanjing University of Finance & Economics, Jun 2023

Dissertation Topic: Towards Sustainable Prosperity? Policy Evaluation of Jiangsu Advanced Manufacturing Clusters

Supervisor: Yabei Hu, Ph.D., Professor of Industrial Organisation and Economics

Key Modules: Microeconomics; Macroeconomics; Econometrics; International Economics; Industrial Organisation; Regional & Urban Economics; Regional Market and Interregional Trade; Business Design & Innovation; Marketing; Business Economics; Economics of Business Enterprise; Retailing and Wholesaling Studies; Economic History

Summer/Winter Schools, Workshops & Seminars

AI in Economic Theory & Methodology, Adv, Prof Yongmiao Hong - Chinese Academy of Sciences, Jul 2024, 2025

Marxian Political Economy, Adv, Prof Shaodong Zhou - Wuhan University, Jul 2023, 2024

Research Methodology in Applied Economics, Adv, Prof Funing Zhong - Nanjing Agricultural University, Aug 2023

Big Data Analytics in GISciences, Adv, Prof Xueying Zhang - Nanjing Normal University, Aug 2023

International Business Management, Prof David French - UCLA & University of Saint Joseph, Jan 2022

Landlord State and Precarious Urban Agriculture in Accra, Prof Dzodzi Tsikata - Edinburgh CAS, Mar 2024

Political Economy of Extractivist Development in Ghana, Dr Gertrude Torvikey - Edinburgh CAS, Nov 2023

Skills, Courses & Certifications

IELTS Academic C1, NCRE L2, Excel & Access & Publisher & Canva (IT Literate & Communication)
Stata & NVivo & ArcMap & VOSviewer & Matlab & CiteSpace (Econometrics, Text Analytics & GISciences)
Understanding Research Methods - SOAS Game Theory - UBC and Stanford University
Korean Economic Development - Yonsei University Local Economic Development - Erasmus University Rotterdam
Microeconomics, Economics of Health Care Delivery, Comparative Health Systems - University of Pennsylvania
Health Systems Development, Epidemiology - University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and Imperial College London
New Structural Economics, Advanced Quantitative Social Research, Science of Logic - Peking University and CUFE

Honours & Awards

Jiangsu Provincial Government Scholarship for Overseas Studies	NUFE Principal's Scholarship
Jiangsu Provincial Distinguished Dissertation Award 1st Class	NUFE Honours Graduate
NUFE Distinguished Dissertation Award	NUFE Honours Student
NUFE Merit Scholarship for Academic Excellence	NUFE Outstanding Student Leader Award
NUFE Merit Scholarship for High Calibre	NNU Outstanding Student Award
WHU Outstanding Student Award	WHU Distinguished Paper Award

Professional Memberships & Activities

Association for Social Economics	Rethinking Economics
Chinese Society of Technology Economics	World Economics Association

PUBLICATIONS

-
- "Towards Sustainable Prosperity? Policy Evaluation of Jiangsu Advanced Manufacturing Clusters," with Yabei Hu*, *Technology in Society*, 2024, 102583, honoured by Jiangsu Provincial Distinguished Dissertation Award

WORK IN PROGRESS

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- "Endogenous Innovation in the Tech Cold War Era," with Li Liu*
 - "Why Cities Backfire? High-Speed Railway New Town Planning and Urban Structural Change," with Yi Zhu
 - "When Polanyi Met Schumpeter: Social Trust and Entrepreneurship," with Weiwei Zhu*, 2025, MPRA 123894
 - "The Third Way: Reinterpreting the Political Settlements Framework with Structuration Theory," 2024, SocArXiv nmvhq
 - "The Road Not Taken? Industrial Policy and Political Settlements in China and Indonesia 1990–2022," 2024, supervised by Dr Hazel Gray, UoE PGSP11291 s2475073, marked as Dissertation of Distinction
 - "It Takes Three to Ceilidh: Pension System and Multidimensional Poverty Mitigation in China," with Yansong Wang*, and Cheng Yuan, 2024, arXiv 2411.02807, (2025 Apr) Birmingham Business School-Nanjing Audit University Institute of Economics International Conference on Ageing, Inequality, and Sustainable Development
 - "Peasant Life in Changing China: Rural Pension System Reform and Social Insurance Participation," with Zhengyi Hu, advised by Dr Yongliang Wu, 2022, arXiv 2204.00785

REPORTS, PRESENTATIONS & BOOK REVIEWS

-
- "Gu Yanwu's Neoclassical Confucianism and Entrepreneurship in Contemporary Kunshan, China," 2025, Kunshan
 - "Transformative Communication in Development Organisation: Strategic Engagement and Celebrity Influence," 2024, MediArXiv 8kabz, Edinburgh
 - "Economic Growth, Poverty Mitigation, and Social Policy in our Neoliberal Era: A Polanyian Perspective," 2024
 - "Crusader Complex: Good Governance and Political Settlements in Africa and Beyond," with Shengjie Zhou, 2024

- “Turbulence and Order in Economic Development: Economic Transformation in Tanzania and Vietnam by Hazel Gray,” 2024, Edinburgh
- “Belt of Productivity, Road to Equality: People First Infrastructure Development in Indonesia,” 2023, Edinburgh
- “Having People, Having Heart: Charity, Sustainable Development, and Problems of Dependence in Central Uganda by China Scherz,” 2023, Edinburgh
- “Common Prosperity and the Middle Class,” *WHU Proceedings of the Summer Institute on Marxian Economics*, 2023, 4, 1–5, Wuhan
- “The Theory of Economic Development by Joseph Schumpeter,” 2022, Nanjing
- “Frontiers and Evolution of Employment Studies in China,” with Weiwei Zhu, advised by Prof Dr Wenwu Zhang, 2021, MPRA 112908, Nanjing
- “Survey on Local Pharmaceutical Specialty Stores: Retail Formats and Elements,” with Yukun Gu, Yibo Wang, Dapeng Zhu, Wei Li, Zhenyu Zhang, Jingxia Hou, and Yuhan Yang, advised by Prof Jinguo Tao, 2021, Nanjing
- “A Study of History by Arnold Toynbee,” 2021, Nanjing
- “Mismatch and Dysfunction of the Ageing Economy: Digital Transformation in Silver-Hair Industry,” with Yukun Gu, Yibo Wang, Yansong Wang, and Qifei Chen, *Journal of the Jiangsu Association for Commercial Economics*, 2021, 38, 1–9, Nanjing
- “Reshaping Silver-Hair Industry with New Retailing: A SWOT-Based Strategy,” *Journal of the China Federation of Logistics*, 2021, 28, 82–85, Nanjing
- “Survey on the Ageing Society in Rural Guannan: Consumption, Social Security, and Manufacturing for Silver-Hair Economy,” with Yukun Gu, and Yibo Wang, advised by Dr Qifei Chen, 2020, Guannan & Nanjing

RESEARCH & PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Fudan University (Shanghai)

2025 – Present

Co-Investigator & Research Associate - Fudan Development Institute

2025 – Present

- Worked on project-oriented research, e.g. ‘*Strategic Optimisation of Global Supply Chain Engagement with Development Zones in China’s Yangtze Economic Belt*’ advised by Dr Li Liu, on 3 projects assigned so far
- Independently conceptualised and drafted the Shanghai Key Think-Tank Project Proposal ‘*Tech Lead Firm Growth and Gradient-Heterogeneous Policy Toolkit*’ with Dr Liu for Shanghai Commission on Technology
- Reviewed cross-disciplinary literature spanning business life cycle, tech supply chain management, regional entrepreneurship, evolutionary innovation & industrial policy, co-authored 2 full reports (30,000+ words)
- Embedded the tech lead firm growth in industrial ecosystem with growing ‘explore’ and ‘exploit’ capabilities
- Examined the interactions between tech lead firms and their localised production spaces of agglomeration economies & ecosystems in Silicon Valley and at the levels of regions, industrial clusters & global networks
- Summarised a list of Shanghai-based pundits in supply chain management for project advisory committee
- Studied bilateral environmental cooperation by identifying funding bodies & foundations supporting China-Brazil tropical forest initiatives
- Conducted a brief review of 20 papers on green agricultural transformation and sustainable rural livelihoods
- Engaged in Shanghai Forum 2025, reflected on talks by Keun Lee, Takehiko Nakao, Woo Wing Thye, Won-soo Kim, Rick Waters, and Michael Levitt on innovation strategy and global techno-nationalist policy change
- Discussed on the political economy of Pakistan’s industrialisation and theoretical complementarity & real-world disequilibrium in China-EU tech trade
- Interpreted the dynamic capabilities of endogenous innovation to sense techno-nationalism, seize the market-technology change, and reconfigure resources through technology exploration, market exploitation & ecosystem orchestration under positive externalities of institutional complementarity

- Clarified technology exploration with the original, recombinant, and incremental capabilities
- Drafted all the sections of a project-based work 'Endogenous Innovation in the Tech Cold War Era'

Research Associate - Fudan Development Institute and Hefei University of Technology 2025 – 2026

- Worked on the 15th Shanghai Government Consultation Research Awarded Project '*Digital Social Innovation and Emerging Industries*', with my subproject focus on new energy vehicle industry
- Articulated the structure of digital social innovation, its conceptual boundaries, actor subjects, objects, networked ecosystems, agendas, and gaps in social-commercial identity duality & techno-determinism
- Comparatively analysed the industrial change of automotive manufacturing in China, Japan, South Korea, Germany & US, and attributed China's to policy experimentation & clustered innovation
- Mapped China's NEV industrial policy trajectory since the 1990s, marked the shift from R&D incentives (tax credits & grants), public procurements, consumer subsidies towards market competition, full-chain industrial coordination & charging infrastructure provision, and drafted policy reports plus supplementary appendices
- Probed state power in NEV innovation ecosystem among governments, lead firms, and research institutions
- Reflected on over 50 multi-source research papers and policy reports to construct a 'tech-industry-society-institution' spiral framework on the co-evolution of digital social innovation and emerging industries
- Schematised that disruptive NEV technologies and digital economy can propel individual-social change
- Stylised facts and proposed recommendations on foresight social governance of industrial ecosystems, particularly regulatory gaps in flexible employment, social security, tax compliance, and labour rights

Shanghai University of Finance & Economics (Shanghai) 2024 – Present

Research Assistant - School of Public Economics & Administration 2024 – Present

- Worked on '*Urban Economics of Land and Transport Infrastructure*' supervised by Prof Dr Yi Zhu
- Advised on a study of the 'Impact of High-Speed Railway New Town Construction on Land Prices: A Case Study in Yangtze Delta Region'
- Delivered suggestions for introduction, literature review, and methodology at the postgraduate level
- Reflectively studied City Economics by Brendan O'Flaherty and Handbook of Regional & Urban Economics by Gilles Duranton, Vernon Henderson, William Strange, Jacques-François Thisse, and Paul Cheshire
- Carried out a critical appraisal of the related work on high-speed railway and industrial change, particularly on the concepts around agglomeration economies, network & spillover effects of diffusion, and the core-periphery framework in urban economics
- Employed the DiD approach, illustrated that HSR town planning in Yangtze Delta cities inhibits the average unit labour productivity of tertiarisation in hub cities but facilitates industrialisation in non-hub ones
- Examined the siphoning of the services in East China that labour & economic activities over-concentrate in core cities and industrial out-diffusion from hub cities enhancing secondary output of non-core areas
- Drafted 'Why Cities Backfire? High-Speed Railway New Town Planning and Urban Structural Change'

Peer Advisor & Teaching Assistant - College of Business 2024 – 2025

- Advised on a Master's dissertation 'Impact of Regional Trade Agreements on Export Resilience' supervised by Prof Dr Linke Zhu, mentored in research design and writing

Peer Advisor - Nanjing University Department of Finance (Nanjing) 2023 – 2025

- Mentored MPhil students in postgraduate-level academic writing and research methodology in economics
- Advice on literature management and tutored in new structural economics & causal inference (Bartik-IV)
- Facilitated collaborative efforts between students and supervisors from Tsinghua University PBC School of Finance and Peking University Guanghua School of Management, advised on original research writing and proposal development towards National Natural Science Foundation of China

- Supported a range of research on political trust in government, state-owned enterprise reform, and economic insecurity & inequality

Nanjing University of Finance & Economics (Nanjing)

2019 – 2024

Co-Investigator & Research Associate - School of International Economics & Business

2022 – 2024

- Worked on National Social Science Fund of China Programme '*Optimisation of Industrial Ecosystems for Advanced Manufacturing Clusters Based on Producer Services*' supervised by Prof Dr Yabei Hu
- Carried out a critical appraisal of the relevant literature on manufacturing and industrial policy, incorporating interdisciplinary knowledge of development economics, international business, and regional science into a coherent theoretical perspective
- Selected, compiled, and perused the publicly available policy documents issued by corresponding functional departments of the Jiangsu government, qualitatively summarised the relevance of the gist
- Operationalised a mixed methodology by a triple analytical framework, both qualitatively and quantitatively analysed a dataset of 52 official documents, scrutinised policy themes, instruments, and controls through textual mining and PMC index modelling
- Independently conducted investigation, data collection, visualisation, theoretical contextualisation, draft writing, submission & communication, and collaborated with PI in validation, interpretation & revision
- Produced original research paper 'Towards Sustainable Prosperity? Policy Evaluation of Jiangsu Advanced Manufacturing Clusters' published in *Technology in Society*, honoured by Provincial Distinguished Award

Peer Advisor - School of Public Administration

2021 – 2022

- Advised on 'Rural Revitalisation: Dilemmas and Prospects of Entrepreneurship in Less-Developed Areas'

Co-Investigator & Coordinator - School of International Economics & Business

2021 – 2022

- Collaboratively worked on National 'Culture, Science & Health to Rural China' Programme '*Cultural Heritage and Industrial Organisation in Less-Developed Areas*' with Weiwei Zhu, honoured by National Excellent Award, Provincial Special Award, and NUFE Best Report Award 1st Class
- Cooperated with the Shuyang government, conducted modern history investigation to organise specialised educational lecture series tailored to regional cultural endowments
- Introduced innovative media campaigns across platforms (Virtual Museum, WeChat, Tiktok & Weibo) to create interactive and immersive visibility and accessibility of cultural heritage towards sustainable public participation and integration of cultural preservation and tourism aligned with economic development

Team Leader - Chinese Society for Optimisation & Economic Mathematics

2021

- Worked on 'MathorCup' Mathematical Contest in Modelling with Yansong Wang and Yukun Gu

Lead Investigator - School of International Economics & Business

2020 – 2021

- Led '*Reshaping Silver-Hair Industry with New Retailing: A Story of China*' advised by Dr Qifei Chen
- Organised the programme from inception to completion, not limited to fundraising, team recruitment, duty allocation, administrative coordination, and resource distribution to ensure timely delivery of research goals
- Reviewed the literature on 'silver-hair economy' & 'new retailing' and designed targeted questionnaires to investigate the consumption behaviour of older adults and market challenges in an ageing society
- Organised fieldwork in Guannan and engaged in face-to-face interviews to capture the nuanced demand preferences of the county older persons in digital technology adoption of new retailing
- Managed online surveys targeting younger individuals, adopted an intergenerational perspective to analyse the influence of younger generations on the familiarity of older adults with smart devices & online shopping
- Identified the supply-demand mismatch in the silver-hair industry, proposed actionable strategy of big data

in e-commerce logistics for rural & urban fringe areas, recommended by Tibet Chief Secretary Chunlai Zhou

- Authored two published reports 'Reshaping Silver-Hair Industry with New Retailing: A SWOT-Based Strategy' & 'Mismatch and Dysfunction of the Ageing Economy: Digital Transformation in Silver-Hair Industry', drafted the working paper 'Rural Pension System Reform and Social Insurance Participation' with feedback from Bangkok-based World Bank economists

Student Assistant - NUFE Admissions Committee 2019 – 2021

Research Assistant - School of Business Administration 2020

- Worked on Jiangsu Administration for Market Regulation Programme '*Customer Satisfaction Evaluation of Tertiary Sector*', ensured public participation of online surveys and collected data

Coordinator Assistant (Intern) - Duke Kunshan University Office of Student Affairs (Kunshan) 2023

- Supported Campus Engagement student worker recruitment & training, interviewed for FYSAC Chairs (14), Orientation Leaders (107) & Commencement Volunteers (97)
- Facilitated liaison between students, faculty & leadership, and coordinated events including DKU Club Expo, Arts Festival & Guest Lectures by Google China and UNHCR
- Handled administrative operations of event logistics, copyright license agreements, reimbursements, and other duties
- Worked as Commencement Committee Assistant, translated & edited Chancellors' Remarks for UG Bulletin, DKU Yearbook & Commencement Brochure, and oversaw bilingual announcement on official website
- Analysed event outcomes with survey data visualisation, proposed reform to student engagement metrics, and co-authored digital communication strategies for Office's WeChat articles & tweets

Executive Assistant & Analyst Associate - HQSW (Kunshan) 2019 – 2022

Advisor Assistant (Intern) - Deloitte Division of Tax (Suzhou) 2021

- Supported preparing a 42-page report with my focus on fixed assets, tax credits, inventories, contingencies, intangible assets, intra-group financing & cross-border business, translated 3 appendices, and selected 8 CAs from 517 for CUP approach to transfer pricing with TP Catalyst
- Compiled financial statements and organisational structures for PETRONAS (PMCL, PLSC & PCMC)
- Advised on tax incentives & industrial layouts for foreign-invested manufacturers in Yangtze Delta and liaised with Xiamen SAFE Bureau & investment promotion agencies on internal capital reallocation accounting

Audit Assistant (Intern) - Mazars Division of Audit and Assurance (Suzhou) 2021

- Assisted with annual audits of Xiangcheng collective assets and Kunshan Hi-Tech Group, with my focus on P&L statement, balance sheet, large transaction, and state-owned asset confirmation
- Drafted 31 sections of audit reports and independently produced 7 audit working papers

Consultant Assistant (Intern) - CITIC Division of Wealth Management (Kunshan) 2020

Research Assistant - Administration for Market Regulation & Bureau of Finance (Kunshan) 2018 – 2020

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Language Proficiency

Fluent in English and Mandarin with a good understanding of Wu and Literary Chinese

Peer Review

PLoS One, Heliyon, Journal of Infrastructure Policy and Development, World Development Sustainability